

Conjunction Agreement as Semantic Agreement*

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Abstract

We discuss number, and to a lesser extent person, feature value cooccurrence restrictions between a head (Tense here) and a conjoined DP subject. We conclude that these restrictions instantiate semantic agreement, which arises in cases in which the features values on T do not match the features values of this DP. In the case of conjunction, this is because, we conclude, a conjunction of DPs lacks such features as there are no syntactic feature resolution rules. Instead, semantic agreement on T is *ad sensum*, meaning based, and can trigger presuppositions on the subject’s denotation. We also discuss cumulative agreement cases, concluding it is not semantic, at least not in the same sense.

Keywords: agreement, semantic agreement, cumulative agreement, number, person, Agree, presupposition, French, English.

1 Introduction

Agreement between a head and a DP is normally assumed to be a formal relation holding in a particular syntactic configuration, typically modeled in terms of Chomsky’s 2000 Agree relation between a probe (the head) and a goal (the DP). In such cases, the features entering into this relation - e.g. ϕ -features, person, number and gender - end up matching in value. Call this syntactic agreement. But there are cases in which a head and a DP display a mismatch in features and a range of unexpected properties, call such cases semantic agreement.

Here, we first briefly introduce such cases of semantic agreement as they arise with collective nouns in certain varieties of English (British, but not only, cf. see [Levin 2001](#)), and some of its properties. We next turn to cooccurrence restrictions in

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number, and to a lesser extent in person, between T and conjoined subjects. We show that they display unexpected properties if it was a formal, syntactic, agreement relation, and also displays characteristic properties of semantic agreement. We conclude that such agreement is always semantic. We attribute this behavior to the conjecture that a conjunction of DPs simply lacks the features required to enter into a formal syntactic agreement relation. Instead, ‘agreement’ is *ad sensum*, meaning based. More specifically, we analyze the features on T as presupposition triggers, constraining the denotation of the subject conjunction, for example singular being only compatible with a conjoined subject denoting a singleton. We also conclude that cumulative agreement cases discussed in [Chaves 2014](#), [Grosz 2015](#), and [Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023](#) is not semantic in the same sense.

2 British Collective Nouns

British collective nouns such as *team*, *committee*, *government*, *family*, *etc...* superficially reference either an abstract entity, a structure, e.g. a family, and/or the individuals composing this structure, the family members:

- (1) a. The committee was founded last year. ($\approx$ the entity was founded.)
- b. The committee is tall ($\approx$ the members are tall.)

This been noted and discussed in the semantic literature (cf. e.g. [Barker 1992](#), [Schwarzschild 1996](#)) along with two different agreement patterns these nouns allow:

- (2) A/*this*/**these* northern team *is/are* playing (plural: $\approx$ the team members are playing)

Example (2) illustrates the two possible agreement options: singular or plural. This is not a case of ambiguous number as the singular *team* may be modified only by a singular determiner, say, the demonstrative *this* and is interpreted as denoting a single team: this shows that the DP *a team* is syntactically only singular. Singular is thus the standard syntactic agreement, but plural is possible: we will call the observed mismatch, here plural features on T with a singular subject, semantic agreement.

What allows (semantic) plural agreement (or a plural reflexive above) is the choice of head noun: replacing *team* by e.g. *music* makes plural agreement unavailable. Semantic agreement with collective nouns thus must be attributed to a property of these nouns. Given the observed variation across English varieties,¹ we take it that there is an idiosyncratic (but not necessarily irregular) property shared by the collective nouns allowing plural agreement that make the minimal DP subject

¹And even within varieties, cf. [Levin 2001](#), or even crosslinguistically: after all, the French counterparts of these nouns mean the same thing, yet disallow plural agreement.

containing them compatible both with singular and plural number on T, even when syntactically singular. As in [Elbourne 1999](#), we take this behavior to be related to the fact that such nouns denote entities with parts, entities that are mereologically plural - a team or a committee or a family has members, across English varieties or languages - and, (partially) as in [Pearson 2011](#) - that they can idiosyncratically denote the plurality of their members despite being singular. This dual status is illustrated by the possibility of having the subject allowing singular agreement on T but anteceding a plural pronoun, a phenomenon sometimes called mixed or hybrid agreement, or agreement shift (cf., e.g. [Levin 2001](#) and references therein, [Smith 2017](#)):²

- (3) This team **is** proud of **themselves**

This is further discussed in [Charnavel & Sportiche 2025](#), which generalizes the treatment of semantic agreement that we advocate below with conjunctions to the case of collective nouns, as well as other structures.

Given the syntactic structure normally attributed to the subject of (2), namely:

- (4) $[DP [D \text{ a/this/*these }] [NOMP [Num \phi_{singular} [NP \text{ team }]]]]$

syntactic agreement would mandate - technically because a Probe stops its search at the closest available Goal - that the ϕ -feature values on T match the ϕ -feature values on Num (or, equivalently here, D, which must match Num). The plural property being a property of the NP *team*, is more deeply embedded than Num and thus can't be accessed, neither by the determiner D (which must thus be singular in (4)) nor by a DP external probe such as T. Now one could try to modify the structure on (4) to make it consistent with the constraints on probe/goal relations but as we discuss in [Charnavel & Sportiche 2025](#), there are no (current) successful proposal that achieves this result and, as we will see, agreement patterns with conjunctions make this goal even more remote. Thus, define semantic agreement as follows:

- (5) Semantic agreement occurs when the ϕ -feature values of the probe mismatch those accessible on the goal DP (that is, the ϕ -feature values of its Num node).³

Now [Sauerland & Elbourne 2002](#) document additional properties of semantic agreement with British collective nouns illustrated by the following examples:

² But this is asymmetric, viz. **This team are proud of itself*. This is discussed in [Smith 2017](#), and from a perspective consistent with the present article in [Charnavel & Sportiche 2025](#).

³This is good enough for our present purpose but may need to be refined, for example depending on how cases of 'unagreement' in [Höhn 2016](#)'s terms discussed in [Höhn 2016](#) and in [Ackema & Neeleman 2018](#) are analyzed. Note also that the reverse may not hold: cumulative agreement discussed below in section 4.5 does not appear to be a case of semantic agreement in the sense discussed here.

- (6) a. There is/*are a northern team playing
 b. (i) A northern team is likely to be playing $a > \textit{likely}; \textit{likely} > a$
 (ii) A northern team are likely to be playing $a > \textit{likely}; *\textit{likely} > a$
1. Example (6a) shows that unlike syntactic agreement, semantic agreement is distributionally restricted (as noted in Sobin 1997 and Munn 1999): it is unavailable in existential constructions, that is in agreement configurations that are taken to motivate an operation of feature matching/valuing /copying under a probe/goal Agree dependency.
 2. Examples in (6b-i) and (6b-ii) show that semantic agreement correlates with an interpretive restriction but syntactic agreement doesn't: while singular agreement allows the raised subject *a northern team* to have either its surface scope (*there is a team and it is likely to be playing*), or to totally reconstruct (*it is likely that there is a team playing*), semantic agreement disallows total reconstruction (see Thoms 2019, for more examples).

This pattern - dual agreement possibilities, simultaneous agreement mismatches, distributional restrictions and interpretive restrictions - must of course be explained and are further discussed in Charnavel & Sportiche 2025. Here, we will simply take, as a starting point, this constellation of properties as characteristic of semantic agreement and discuss the case of agreement with conjunctions.

3 Conjunction and Agreement

In this section, we are primarily concerned with Subject Verb (or Subject Tense) patterns of number agreement in the standard SV order in French and English when the subject is a conjunction of two (or more) DPs. A standard view is that such SV agreement is syntactic: the subject has some syntactically accessible ϕ -feature values for person and number (and gender in some languages) and the verb (or perhaps more precisely T) displays the same feature values.

We will argue, along with a number of other authors (e.g. Farkas & Zec 1995, Doron 2000 and others since) that there is no syntactic resolution of features values for a whole conjunction on the basis of the individual feature values of the conjunct. Instead, at least for person and number agreement, agreement is always semantic in the sense discussed above: the person and number features on a head agreeing with a conjunction trigger a semantic presupposition on the denotation of the whole conjunction.

3.1 Some Basic Observations

Consider the following examples:

- (7) a. Tam et Zadig ont bien ri
 Tam and Zadig have laughed a lot

- b. *Tam et Zadig a bien ri
*Tam and Zadig has laughed a lot
- c. Tam et Zadig ont chanté ensemble
Tam and Zadig have sung together
- d. *Tam et Zadig a chanté ensemble
*Tam and Zadig has sung together

Sentences (7a) and (7c) are taken to be unsurprising: the subject is a conjunction of two singular DPs, it is typically assumed that the conjunction is somehow resolved as syntactically plural, triggering plural agreement on the verb. Similarly, in (7b) and (7d), the conjunction being resolved as syntactically plural disallows singular agreement on the verb. But some observations - some from Charnavel 2010 - raise challenges for this picture.

First consider the following paradigm of conjoined singular indefinites with *un/a* (the results would be the same with singular definites *le, la/ the*):

- (8) a. Un/le garçon et une/la fille *a/ont dansé ensemble. collective
'A/the boy and a/the girl *has/have danced together.'
- b. Un/le garçon et une/la fille *a/ont bien ri. distributive
'A/the boy and a girl/la *has/have laughed a lot.'

We see that the agreement pattern is insensitive to whether the predicate is collective or distributive. But if we conjoin DPs quantified with *chaque / each* or *aucun / no*, the pattern changes as singular agreement becomes acceptable with distributive predicates:

- (9) a. Chaque fille et chaque garçon *a/ont dansé ensemble. collective
'Each girl and each boy *has/have danced together.'
- b. Chaque fille et chaque garçon a/?ont bien ri. distributive
'Each girl and each boy has/?have laughed a lot.'
- (10) a. Aucune fille ni/et aucun garçon n'*a/ont dansé ensemble. collective
'No girl and no boy *has/have danced together.'
- b. Aucune fille ni/et aucun garçon n'a/?ont bien ri. distributive
'No girl and no boy has/?have laughed a lot.'

3.2 Constituent Sharing?

This paradigm illustrates the fact that agreement possibilities are sensitive to the meaning of the VP predicate. How could this come about? Given that French, or English, allows constituent sharing via some kind of clausal coordination reduction as illustrated below, call it C(onstituent) S(haring), which following Barros & Vicente 2011, Chaves 2014 and Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023, we take to involve a biclausal analysis with (at least) two distinct processes, backwards ellipsis of the shared constituent and another process, say, for concreteness here, multidominance

CS to make these pairs parallel. Instead, the pattern seems to be sensitive to the denotational properties of the conjuncts, indefinites (or in fact definites) in one case, quantifiers in the other: agreement seems to be sensitive to how the subject conjunction is interpreted. For example, sentence (9b) with singular agreement, *chaque fille et chaque garçon a bien ri* / *each girl and each boy has laughed a lot* can be paraphrased by ‘*each person who is a boy or a girl has laughed a lot*’, behaving in effect as a singular *each NP*. Whereas example (14), a conjunction of (in)definites with singular agreement *a/the boy and a/the girl has laughed a lot* cannot be. It cannot mean: ‘*a person who is a/the boy or a/the girl has laughed a lot*’.

3. Third, why do we observe the following contrast between the cases of conjunction of (in)definites (14) and (15):

- (14) Un/le célibataire et un/l’ homme marié *a/ont bien ri. distributive
‘A/the bachelor and a/the married man *has/have laughed a lot.’
- (15) a. **Un** père dévoué et **un** collègue sympathique va/vont lire cet article.
‘A devoted father and a friendly colleague is/are going to read this article.’
b. **Le** père dévoué que nous apprécions et **le** collègue sympathique que nous estimons tous va/vont lire cet article
‘The devoted father that we value and the friendly colleague efficient that we all respect will-read-SG/*PL this article.’

The only difference is, again, the denotation of the conjunction of DPs. Here the denotation of the two conjuncts must be different in (14) since a bachelor cannot be a married man. But they can be the same in (15). And the choice of agreement correlates with the interpretation: with singular, the two conjuncts must have the same denotation. Plural agreement favors the opposite (but does not entirely require it, with an individual seen under different guises).⁴

4. In addition there are cases in which CS is not possible but singular agreement is possible.

- (16) a. Aucun professeur_m et aucun élève de sa classe n’a /ont bien ri
No professor_m and no student from his class_m has /have laughed a lot
b. Aucun contrat_m and aucune de ses_m versions antérieures n’a/ont de valeur

⁴Similar examples are discussed in Hoeksema 1988: p.36 and Winter 2001: p.178 under the name of appositional conjunction. The latter’s analysis in terms of conjunction of NPs (properties) type shifted to a single individual is insufficiently general as shown by the examples with *chaque*, *aucun/each*, *no*. Other examples due to Hoeksema such as: **Dr. Jekyll and Mr. Hyde has passed away*, **Charles Dodgson and Lewis Carroll has passed away*, **Charles Dodgson and the author of Alice has passed away* which Winter 2001 takes to illustrate that singular agreement only occurs with conjunction of properties (and see Coppock & Beaver 2015, for why definites would qualify), seem to us to show instead that denotation per se is not quite the right notion. Rather, as Hoeksema had it, the relevant notion is intensional: what counts are personae. Dr Jekyll and Mister Hyde, despite being the same person, count as distinct entities. We ignore this finer point throughout in this article.

légale No contract_m and none of its_m previous versions has/ have any legal force

The reading of interest here is one in which the DP indexed *m* binds the pronoun indexed *m*, which is compatible with singular agreement. If, for example, the first sentence involved CS, it would have the structure:

- (17) No boy_m ~~has laughed a lot~~ and no girl who knows him_m has laughed a lot

But such a structure should be ill-formed with the pronoun bound, as it would not be in the scope of its binder. Indeed, such (downward entailing) quantifiers cannot bind across clauses (unlike others which allow so-called telescoping - see e.g. [Keshet 2008](#)). This is corroborated by the following ill-formed case of CS involving pronominal binding (particle *ne* omitted here as in spoken French):⁵

- (18) Aucun professeur_m a dit que Marie ~~défendrait ce projet~~ et Anne a dit qu'aucun de ses_m élève défendrait ce projet
 * No professor_m said that Mary ~~would vouch for this project~~, and Ann said that no student from his_m class, would vouch for this project

Conclusion: We conclude that there are cases of conjoined subjects compatible with singular agreement on T that do not involve CS, which require no special intonational contour, but rather depend on the interpretive properties of this conjunction. We now turn to how to handle such patterns.

4 Semantic Agreement with Conjunctions

4.1 Conjunction agreement: only semantic

Looking again at the examples discussed, they do not relevantly differ in their syntactic composition; compare (14) and (15). If there were a purely syntactic computation of ϕ -features values for the whole conjunction on the basis of the feature make up of the conjuncts, this should be blind to how the conjuncts denote, and we would expect only one kind of agreement to be possible (namely plural, presumably).⁶ We

⁵An English speaking reviewer finds binding in (16) unavailable not because of agreement but because of the binding of the first conjunct into the second. This judgment is simply not shared either by us or the French speakers we surveyed who find (16) natural and a contrast with (18). Note also that such cases of binding by a negative quantifier into its conjunct are reported as well formed in the literature on (American) English, e.g. *No soldier and his rifle should ever be separated* in [Munn 1993](#): p. 34, an interesting example as it cannot involve Constituent Sharing because of the binding, because of the NPI *ever* that would not be licensed in its clause and because of the choice of the verb *separate*.

⁶This contradicts some reports, for example [Corbett 2006](#): p. 242: (a) If there are two conjuncts only, both singular, then agreement will be dual. (b) In all other cases agreement will be plural.

conclude that there is no such syntactic feature resolution in conjunctions, agreeing with previous authors e.g. [Farkas & Zec 1995](#), [Doron 2000](#), or more recently [Kučerová 2018](#), [Harbour 2020](#). This means that there is no possibility of syntactic agreement. Instead, we will pursue, and justify a different option, namely that agreement with conjunctions is always semantic in nature, in classical terms agreement is *ad sensum* instead of *ad formam*: this is the only option given the mismatch between the features on T and the (lack of) features on the whole conjunction.

To derive this pattern of data, we propose, as inspired by [Sportiche 2016](#), to treat ϕ -features values on heads (here T) in cases of semantic agreement as presupposition triggers the way ϕ -features values are normally treated on pronouns. In other words:⁷

- (19) **Meaningful Agreement:** In Number and Person semantic agreement between a head H and a DP, the ϕ features values on H trigger their standard presupposition on the DP.

In other words, a plural feature on T will require its subject to denote a plurality; a singular feature will require it to denote a singleton; a 1st person feature will require the subject to function like a first person pronoun etc... One such example with person is the following:

- (20) L'un d'entre nous/*eux et l'un d'entre vous sommes prêts à partir
 one of us/*them and one of you are-1stpl ready to leave

This example requires the denotation of the subject to include the speaker via the presence of a first person pronoun, as expected given the first person plural agreement on the verb.

4.2 How it applies

Consider examples in (15), repeated below:

- (15) a. **Un** père dévoué et **un** collègue sympathique va lire cet article.
 'A devoted father and a friendly colleague is going to read this article.'
 b. **Le** père dévoué que nous apprécions et **le** collègue sympathique que nous estimons tous va lire cet article
 'The devoted father that we value and the friendly colleague that we all respect will read this article.'

Number agreement being presuppositional, singular number requires that the conjunction denote to a single individual. This is possible if the denotations of the

⁷This will be good enough for our purposes here, but it ignores relevant issues discussed e.g. in [Magri 2012](#), [Pearson 2011](#) or [de Vries 2015](#). These issues are discussed in [Charnavel & Sportiche 2025](#).

two conjuncts are identical, and only in such a case. This arises because the domain of quantification here can be the intersection of $[[\text{devoted father}]]$ and $[[\text{friendly colleague}]]$, it is the set of people who are both.

Now turn to the quantified examples, e.g. those in (9) repeated below:

- (21) a. Chaque fille et chaque garçon ***a/ont** dansé ensemble. collective
 'Each girl and each boy *has/have danced together.'
 b. Chaque fille et chaque garçon **a/?ont** bien ri. distributive
 'Each girl and each boy has/?have laughed a lot.'

These sentences involve an ambiguity, as follows:⁸

- (22) a. Each boy and each girl $\approx$ each $x, x \in [[\text{boy}]] \cup [[\text{girl}]] \rightarrow$ Singular
 b. Each boy and each girl $\approx$ (each $x, x \in [[\text{boy}]]$) $\wedge$ (each $x, x \in [[\text{girl}]]$) $\rightarrow$ Plural

The first interpretation is that of 'each boy and girl' where *boy and girl* is interpreted cumulatively, that is as denoting the set $[[\text{boy}]] \cup [[\text{girl}]]$, which is independently possible (see e.g. Schmitt 2019 or Schmitt 2020). This behaves like a singular *each boy*, consistent with the singular presupposition encoded on T. So condition (19) is met. Returning now to (14) repeated below:

- (14) Un célibataire et un homme marié ***a/ont** bien ri. distributive
 'A bachelor and a married man *has/have laughed a lot.'

Neither of the two interpretations needed to trigger singular agreement is available. First, the two conjuncts cannot denote the same person who would need to simultaneously be a bachelor and a married man. Next, a cumulative interpretation, namely 'a person who is either a bachelor or a married man', that would trigger singular agreement is not available either with the determiners *un, le, la /a, the*: the expression *a/the bachelor and married man* can only denote an individual who is both a bachelor and a married man (which is not possible). Singular agreement is thus barred. The only interpretation is a conjunction of two singular expressions denoting two people. This yields a plurality denoting subject, only compatible with plural agreement, regardless of the choice of predicate.

In all these cases, we simply note that the relevant interpretations are possible, but we do not discuss how precisely they arise. For example in (22), the relevant interpretation is available but how to precisely get it is unclear. It could involve ATB QR of *each*: this would yield *each x, boy(x) and girl(x)* with *and* interpreted

⁸It would be the same for *aucun/no*

Aucun garçon ni aucune fille $\approx$ No $x, x \in [[\text{boy}]] \cup [[\text{girl}]] \rightarrow$ Singular

Aucun garçon ni aucune fille $\approx$ (No $x, x \in [[\text{boy}]]$) $\wedge$ (No $x, x \in [[\text{girl}]]$) $\rightarrow$ Plural

either intersectively which is unlikely in this context and would yield the wrong truth conditions, or more plausibly cumulatively yielding the right truth conditions to license singular agreement. In (14), a cumulative reading is not available. The cumulative reading of *each boy and each girl* is equivalent to *each boy or girl*, but this is not so for *a boy and a girl*. Why is unclear. Relevant discussion can be found in Heycock & Zamparelli 2005, Schmitt 2019 or Schmitt 2020.

4.3 Independent evidence

If agreement with conjunction is semantic, this makes the prediction that it should behave like semantic agreement with British collective nouns. We expect that there should not be agreement with the conjunction in existential constructions, and in total reconstruction cases. Both predictions are borne out, the first one straightforwardly, the second needing some discussion which will be provided in section 4.5. The prediction straightforwardly borne out in the case of existential constructions is illustrated below:⁹

- (23) a. There i. *was/ ii. were several people here
 b. There i. was / ii. *were a woman and a girl here

Example (23b) illustrates the long-noted (see e.g. Sobin 1997) ill-formed plural agreement with a conjunction of singulars DPs. This parallels what is observed in example (6b-i) with British collective nouns. This contrasts minimally with a case in which agreement can be syntactic in (23a) which displays the reverse pattern.¹⁰ Such contrasts supports the conclusion that agreement with conjunctions is exclusively semantic.

4.4 Deriving the properties of semantic agreement

Condition (19) derives why semantic agreement is excluded in existential constructions. This is due to two factors: (i) the independent scopal properties of the associate of *there*, and (ii) semantic agreement is presuppositional. Factor (i) is illustrated by the following examples:

⁹Singular agreement here arises via first conjunct agreement, as shown by *there *was / were two women and a man here*.

¹⁰We use past tense to control away from the form *there's* that can be used with present tense meaning and which we otherwise ignore. It seems to have an intermediate status, except when singular agreement would otherwise be allowed as in *there's a book*, according to Sobin 1997. For example, the sentence

i. *There's several people here*

with contraction is generally judged better than (23a)i. In Sobin's survey, it is rated 2.58 on a 0-5 scale, with (23a)i/ii rated 1.39/4.31 respectively, and (23b)i/ii rated 3.58/0.81 respectively (with *there's* rated 4.36). This suggests that *there's* can be the well behaved contracted form of *there is*. Its status elsewhere is unclear, including whether it involves agreement at all and what syntax it has.

- (24) In existential constructions, the associate of *there* is scope frozen, viz.
- a. If there always is a soldier here.. $\checkmark \text{always}/\exists; * \exists > \text{always}$
 $\checkmark$ meaning: if it is always the case that there is a soldier here...
 $*$ meaning: if there is a soldier who is always here...
 - b. If a soldier is always here... $\checkmark \text{always}/\exists; \checkmark \exists > \text{always}$

The observation (24) (which needs to be independently explained) is this: as shown in (b), *a soldier* can scope under or above the adverb *always*, meaning either *there is a soldier who is always here* or *it is always the case that there is a soldier*. But in (a), only the second reading is available.

Factor (ii) has to do with how presuppositions are allowed to be cashed out. Being interpretive properties, they are cashed out on the basis of LF representations. But presuppositional properties of an item X are limited as to what the presupposition can be about. Informally formulated:¹¹

- (25) A presuppositional property on X imposes interpretive restrictions on:
- a. X itself (e.g. ϕ -features on a pronoun) or
 - b. one of X's arguments, here A or B
 (e.g. *again*, *quickly* on a VP it modifies, *sleep* on its subject, *stop*, *regret* on their objects, ...)

In other words, presuppositions carried by X impose local restrictions on X's environment: X's sister or X's subject. Fundamentally, this is a subcase of the general Locality of Selection Principle.

If ϕ -features on T are presuppositional, they cannot meet (25a), so they must meet (25b). As T takes a DP subject, model T as a partial function taking a DP subject as a syntactic argument with which it may agree and a (VP) complement as syntactic and semantic argument. Given the nature of ϕ -features on T and of T, the only option is for these ϕ -features to constrain the denotational possibilities of the subject of T. As a consequence, in an existential construction, agreement on T imposes a presupposition on the subject of T at LF. But factor (i) prevents the associate of *there* from occupying such a position at LF (it is scope frozen). This correctly predicts the ill-formedness of examples such as (23b).

The very same reasoning predicts another property of semantic agreement, namely that semantically agreeing subjects cannot reconstruct as in (6b-ii). If they did, they would occupy a lower position at LF and the required relation between the presupposition trigger on T and its subject would not longer hold. This should hold of conjunctions but it superficially seems to be incorrect: it does hold however and we now turn to a discussion of why.

¹¹Formally, the first case reduces to the second as in Heim 2008.

(26) a. If [DP_* a man and a woman] were always here...
 ✓ $DP_* > \text{always}$ /✓ $\text{always} > DP_*$
 b. LF for $\text{always} > DP_*$: [were [always [[DP_* a man and a woman] here]]]

Here we discuss the possibility¹² that (26a) is structurally ambiguous. Narrow scope for a conjunction of DPs would be excluded, but not narrow scope under the following structural analysis involving a shared constituent - here *were always here*:

Narrow scope would not be excluded if:

- We discuss these two points in turn.

(28) Jean dit que Jeannette, et Pierre dit que Pierrette, est/ **sont** à Paris
Jean says that Jeannette, and Pierre says that Pierrette, is/ **are** in Paris

¹²This is not the only possibility. Another possible analytical path would tie this possibility to the fact that, contrary to what happens with collective nouns, agreement with conjunction must be semantic.

¹³The somewhat degraded singular agreement in (14) could thus be due to a competition between cumulative plural and standard singular agreement in CS cases. We may therefore conclude that CS is possible even in cases like (14), requiring some intonational signature and allowing plural agreement even if the subject is singular in each conjunct.

One type of analysis of such cumulative agreement is found in Grosz 2015, similar to that of Yatabe 2003. It takes the shared constituent to be multidominated, simultaneously belonging to two clauses, each with its own singular subject. This shared constituent agrees with the two singular subjects yielding plural agreement features on the verb.

We thus tie reconstruction in (23a) to cumulative agreement. This means that if we observe a similar structure but we rule out the possibility that cumulative agreement is involved, reconstruction should be blocked. To control away from plural agreement being cumulative in a reduced coordination configuration, using downward entailing quantifiers/modifiers as in (16) and (17) is not possible because they resist reconstruction (viz. *seul un homme est toujours là/ only a man is always here*, **always>only* or *aucune femme n'est toujours là/ no woman is always here*, **always>neg*). But we can control away from reduced coordination with collective predicates, as Grosz 2015 reports that a shared collective predicate disallows cumulative agreement:¹⁴

- (29) *Pierre dit que Pierrette et Jean dit que Jeannette ont dansé
 *Pierre says that Pierrette and Jean says that Jeannette have danced
 ensemble.
 together.

Now in such cases, reconstruction of the conjoined subject is degraded. Consider the following cases:¹⁵

¹⁴ Some speakers agree but not all. To the latter, if the shared constituent is new information (e.g. as an answer to ‘what’s new?’ or ‘what did they say?’), this sentence is indeed degraded. But in a context in which it is known that some two people have danced together, and the sentence reports the partial knowledge that Jean and Pierre have about who they are, the sentence is fine. In other words, the sentence is fine if the plural inflected verb is not part of the sentence focus. We stay away from such cases/speakers in what follows.

¹⁵ A more subtle case can be made on the basis of examples such as (15) repeated below:

(15) a. **Un** père dévoué et **un** collègue sympathique va lire cet article.

‘A devoted father and a friendly colleague is going to read this article.’

A CS analysis of such sentences would take them to have the structure:

i. Un père dévoué va lire cet article et **un** collègue sympathique va lire cet article.

‘A devoted father is going to read this article and a friendly colleague is going to read this article.’

Normally the unshared portions of CS structures should contrast: this leads to interpreting the two subjects are not co-denoting. As a result, when they do co-denote, a biclausal analysis is dispreferred, perhaps excluded. This means that in the following cases where the two conjuncts co-denote, no CS analysis is available and reconstruction should be blocked. This seems correct:

ii. #Un père dévoué et un patron sympathique est souvent mort dans les dix dernières années

A devoted father and a friendly boss often died in the last ten years

Such sentences are odd: because reconstruction is blocked, the subject cannot scope under the frequency adverb and the sentence assumes that it is true of a particular individual that he often died in the last ten years.

- (30) un policier et un soldat sont toujours de garde (ensemble)
a policeman and a soldier are always on duty (together)

If *ensemble/together* is absent, the conjunction can scope under the frequency adverb, meaning that it is always the case that a policeman and a soldier are on guard duty. This is possible because this can be analyzed as a reduced clausal conjunction with cumulative agreement. But if *ensemble/together* is present, such a reading is degraded.¹⁶

Similarly, consider the following examples:

- (31) a. Dans ce village, des membres d'une même famille
In this village, members of a same family
se sont souvent mariés ensemble.
often married each other.
b. Dans ce village, un homme et une femme d'une même famille
In this village, a man and a woman of a same family
se sont souvent mariés ensemble.
often married each other.

We observe the same pattern. In both cases, the predicate is collective, excluding an analysis in terms of reduced clausal conjunction with cumulative agreement. In the first example, the subject can scope under the frequency adverb meaning *it is often the case that there are members of a same family marrying each other*. The second sentence is odd, as it describes a couple repeatedly marrying each other: the scopal relation the first sentence supports is degraded.

Before closing this section, note that the view that cumulative agreement is syntactically based is challenged in [Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023](#). We now briefly discuss why their objections are not relevant to our conclusions.

[Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023](#)'s discussion of cumulative agreement arises in the context of a discussion of C(onstituent) S(haring) configurations - the main focus of their article - as in:

- (32) John read and Mary commented this article

Such constructions have received different analyses. [Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023](#) adopts the conclusion defended in [Barros & Vicente 2011](#), [Chaves 2014](#) and [Hirsch & Wagner 2015](#)) for example, according which such constructions involve a biclausal analysis involving (at least) two distinct processes: backwards ellipsis of the (apparently) shared constituent, or multidominance of the shared constituent (as in [Bachrach & Katzir 2009](#), [Barros & Vicente 2011](#), [Hirsch & Wagner 2015](#)):

¹⁶For all these examples, there is a clear contrast but it is difficult to decide whether the relevant reading is totally unavailable for this form. We assume it is but this should be controlled by properly designed experimental studies.

- (33) a. John bought and Mary sold several books
 b. John bought ~~several books~~ and Mary sold several books Ellipsis
 c. [John [bought
 and [several books]] Multidominance
 [Mary [sold

This conclusion is based on the observation made in [Barros & Vicente 2011](#) that four properties displayed by CS configurations, - morphological mismatches or vehicle change between conjuncts, cumulative agreement and internal readings for relational elements like *same/different* - do not all cooccur freely. Instead, the first two are characteristic of Ellipsis but are not allowed under Multidominance, while the last two are consistent with Multidominance (and may also be consistent with Ellipsis in case Ellipsis is combined with Multidominance, as [Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023](#) argues). Now [Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023](#) also conclude that in:

- (34) Jean dit que Jeannette, et Pierre dit que Pierrette, ont démissionné.
 Jean says that Jeannette, and Pierre says that Pierrette, have resigned.

The plural-marked constituent *ont démissionné/ have resigned*, call it VP+, has the following property so plural agreement is interpreted.

- (35) [[VP+]] holds of a plural individual (when it carries plural features).

This conclusion faces difficulties we now discuss:

First, [Belk, Neeleman & Philip \(2023: p. 265, fn5\)](#) report the following in (36a):

- (36) a. Susan reports that no doctor, and Carla reports that no nurse, has/*have traveled to Cameroon.
 b. Suzanne rapporte qu'aucun médecin et Carla rapporte qu'aucun
 Suzanne reports that no doctor and Carla reports that no
 infirmier, n'ira/iront au Cameroon.
 nurse, will-go-sg/will-go-pl to Cameroon

The deviance of plural agreement in (36a) is consistent with (35) as, presumably, nobody relevant traveled to Cameroon. However, we have not been able to duplicate this judgement with consulted speakers of English (who do note that while plural agreement is normally preferred over singular agreement in such cases, here both are equally possible). At any rate, such sentences are fully acceptable in French as shown in (36b) above.¹⁷ This is inconsistent with (35).

Second, [Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023](#) does not discuss how (35) interacts with the meaning of the whole sentence in CS configurations. What does (35) mean regarding what Jean or Pierre said in (34)? One option would be that Jean said that

¹⁷The same holds of sentences with universal quantifiers reported as degraded [Belk, Neeleman & Philip \(2023: p. 265, fn5\)](#): plural agreement is as acceptable in French as the simple (9b); this is also true of some speakers of English at least.

Jeannette is a member of a set of people who left and Peter said that Pierrette is too. But this not what the sentence means. Rather, the speaker may simply be reporting Jean and Pierre’s partial knowledge as to who resigned. For example, this sentence is true in a context C in which Jean said: *the only thing I know is that Jeannette left. She may have left alone, or with others, I do not know*, and Peter said the same thing. Another option would be to assume that the plurality of the plurality denoting VP+ is interpreted outside of the scope of the attitude verbs (admittedly a rather far fetched assumption), that is, with (35) as holding *de re*, but not *de dicto*: the sentence would then express the meaning: *more than one person left and Jean said that Jeannette left and Pierre said that Pierrette left*. But this does not have to be the case. For example in context C, the speaker may be entirely agnostic or ignorant about what is the case, simply reporting Jean and Pierre’s answer to the question: so what’s new? This shows that there are contexts in which (35) holds neither *de re* nor *de dicto*. This means that (35) cannot be true: the plural marking cannot be interpreted.

Note that a purely syntactic agreement triggers no interpretive entailment or presupposition, consistent with a context such as C.

Our conclusion that (plural) cumulative agreement cannot be interpreted, or that it cannot be interpreted as presuppositional suffices for our present purpose. Needless to say, we do not address all the issues raised by cumulative agreement, nor do justice to the data Belk, Neeleman & Philip 2023 claims support (35), nor to some of the issues raised in Grosz 2015. We conclude that the availability of reconstruction with conjoined subjects in some circumstances is consistent with the predictions made by assuming that agreement with conjoined subjects is always semantic.

5 Conclusion

There are cases such as British English collective noun headed DPs in which agreement is not driven by the ϕ -feature values of this DPs. We call these cases semantic agreement.

We have argued that agreement with conjunctions behaves much like semantic agreement with British collective nouns.

To explain the behaviour of conjunctions, we have concluded in agreement with previous work that at least for person and number, there is no syntactic resolution mechanisms that compute ϕ -feature values for the whole conjunction on the basis of those of the individual DPs that compose it. As a result, there is no possibility of conjunctions syntactically agreeing: agreement with conjoined DPs must be semantic.

We have also concluded that with semantic agreement, the ϕ -features values on T trigger a presupposition on its subject, spec TP. The interpretive nature of this condition derives why a semantic agreement configuration must hold at LF

condition, as argued in [Sportiche 2016](#), or [Smith 2017](#), and why in a specifier/head configuration.

Our discussion was limited to subject/tense agreement but would extend to other agreeing heads and their subjects. It was also limited to number agreement and to a lesser extent person agreement.

We did not discuss whether and how it could extend to gender agreement. A natural extension would be to take gender feature values as presuppositional as well: much like with pronouns, a gender feature requires either a referent with matching gender (*she* denotes a female), or, and this is where gender differs from person or number, a referent (contextually) reachable by a DP of a matching grammatical gender (*elle/she* can denote the moon when talking about the moon, because in French, *lune/moon* is of feminine grammatical gender). Such an approach seems consistent with the conclusions reached in [Adamson & Anagnostopoulou 2024](#)) but of course, more work is needed as the set of gender feature values does not have a natural ordering relation the way the sets of person feature values, or of number feature values number do.

We also left open a number of further questions.

If the view that we have developed is correct, ϕ -features on T can be generated and valued independently of T's syntactic environment. We have not discussed how this affects how to model the Agree relation, requiring it, under minimal assumptions, to involve matching feature values between a probe and a goal, rather than copying or valuing. Nor have we discussed exactly how the division of labor arises between syntactic and semantic agreement.

We have not discussed how our conclusions regarding conjunctions extends to British collective nouns and their complex properties, some discussed in [Smith 2017](#). Nor did we discuss how they extend to other cases such as partitive and pseudo-partitive constructions which display characteristic properties of semantic agreement.

Some of these questions are addressed in [Charnavel & Sportiche 2025](#).